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Let There Be Space!

With the ever increasing size of personal and professional data, most of us just cannot make do with thumb drives and CD-Rs. Meet the external drives that have come to save the day!

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It all began with the first production model—the IBM 305RAMAC (Random Access Method of Accounting and Control) hard drive in 1956. It had a mere 5 MB of space and had writing speeds of about 8 KB/s—hardly considered a hard drive today!

We have, since then, come a long way, but our desire to cram more and more into less and less space has grown exponentially. Thankfully, so has the capacity of the hard disks of today.

Most computer systems today come with 40 GB as the default disk space, and people are already finding this insufficient—so 80 GB hard drives are becoming increasingly common.

The limitation with these drives is that they aren't really plug and play. Sure, if you're a tech-savvy person, it just means disconnecting a data cable and a power supply cable, and porting it around - but for the rest of us, messing around with the internals of a computer isn't an exciting option. Enter external hard disk drives. Let there be, umm, space!

Understanding The Tests

We realised there are broadly two usage patterns for external hard disks. One is for people such as graphic artists or designers and photographers who need to carry a fairly large amount of data back and forth between the workplace and the home or other places. For such people on the move, we tested portable drives.

The other usage pattern that exists would be the data backup and storage kind. Here, the need is basically to back up lots of data - probably once a day or once a week - and the backup device will stay put on your desktop, whether at home or at the office. For this, we tested desktop storage and backup drives.

We conducted the following series of tests:

Drive Index: A cumulative figure that gives an overall performance grade based on the average of read, write and seek tests, as well as the file and cache size of the disk. The drive index simulates, and hence benchmarks, the drive performance under typical PC usage, so the higher the score, the better the drive.